



The Language of the Job

Ace Dispatch · Dispatcher Training Course

Module 1 of 18 · Foundations · about a 14-minute read

Walk onto a dispatch floor on your first day, and here's what you'll hear someone say:

"I've got a van running empty out of Atlanta, deadheading to a reefer load, broker wants the rate con signed before the driver hits the dock, and they're FCFS — so watch the detention."

If that sounded like a foreign language — good. It's supposed to. Every dispatcher who is good at this job today once heard that exact wall of noise and understood none of it. Here's the secret they figured out: it's not actually a lot of words. It's about **thirty**. And they all hang on one simple thing — the journey of a single load, from the moment a company needs something moved to the moment the money hits the bank.

So that's what we're going to do. We're not going to memorize a dictionary. We're going to follow one truck, one load, **Atlanta to Dallas**, all the way through — and pick up the language exactly where it lives. By the end, that sentence won't sound like noise. It'll sound like your job.

WHAT YOU'LL BE ABLE TO DO

Know the cast of characters, the equipment, where the work comes from, how it pays, and the three pieces of paper that run every load. You won't have all thirty words memorized cold today — and you don't need to. You'll *recognize* them. That's the whole win for lesson one, and it's the foundation everything else is built on.

1 The People

One running example carries this whole lesson: a furniture company in Atlanta shipping a big order to a store in Dallas. Each part below is one move of that load.

Our load starts with a furniture company in Atlanta. They make couches and sell them, and a store in Dallas just placed a big order. The problem: this company makes furniture — they don't own trucks. The business that has goods that need to move, and where the money to move them comes from, is the **shipper**. The shipper is where the whole chain starts and where the money starts.

Now, the shipper *could* go hunting for a truck themselves. Most don't. It's easier to call a **broker** — a middleman whose entire job is connecting shippers who have freight with trucks that can haul it. The broker doesn't own a single truck. They make the match, and they take a cut for it. You'll spend a huge part of your career talking to brokers.

The truck itself belongs to a **carrier** — the trucking company that actually hauls the freight, operating under its own legal authority to do so. A carrier might be a thousand trucks, or it might be one person who owns his rig. Either way: the carrier is the company that moves the load.

And behind that truck, making it all happen, is the **dispatcher**. That's you. The dispatcher works *for the carrier* — finding the loads, booking them, scheduling the stops, and keeping the truck rolling and the driver supported. Hold onto this: **you work for the carrier, not the broker and not the shipper. Your job is to make your truck money.**

The person actually turning the wheel is the **driver**. Sometimes the driver owns the truck, sometimes they're employed to drive it — for now, just know the driver is the one out on the road.

Two more characters show up near the end of the trip. When the truck reaches Dallas, the business on the receiving dock takes the freight — that's the **receiver** (you'll also hear them called the *consignee*). And once it's delivered, the carrier usually waits weeks to get paid — but the driver needs fuel *today*. So there's often a **factor**: a company that pays the carrier fast, right after delivery, then waits around to collect the slow payment itself, for a small fee.

That's your whole cast — and they line up in the exact order the load moves:



Seven players, one journey. We go deep on all seven — and how the money moves between them — in the very next lesson.

2 The Equipment

Now, the truck. It's really two pieces. The front piece — the cab, the engine, where the driver sits — is the **tractor**. The box behind it that actually holds the freight is the **trailer**. And trailers come in types, which matters because the *type* decides what you can haul.

The most common one, by far, is the **dry van** — picture a fifty-three-foot enclosed metal room on wheels. It hauls anything that doesn't need special treatment: boxes, pallets, furniture. Our Dallas load fits a dry van.

Looks almost identical from the outside, but very different inside, is the **reefer** — short for refrigerated. It's a dry van with a cooling unit bolted on the front, for anything that has to stay cold: produce, frozen food, some medicine.

Then there's the **flatbed** — exactly what it sounds like. An open deck, no walls, no roof, for freight that's too big or too oddly shaped to fit in a box: steel beams, lumber, a bulldozer.

And here's a word you will hear ten times a day: **deadhead**. That's driving *empty* — no load, no money, just burning fuel to reposition the truck. Deadhead miles are pure cost, and a huge part of your job is killing them. When you hear "deadhead," hear "*I'm losing money right now.*"

3 Finding the Load

So the broker has the shipper's furniture that needs to get from Atlanta to Dallas. That route — one place to another — has a name in this business: a **lane**. Atlanta to Dallas is a lane. Dispatchers think and talk in lanes all day.

How do you even find out this load exists? The broker posts it on a **load board** — an online marketplace where brokers list the freight they need moved and carriers shop for it. This is where a big chunk of your day lives: searching the board for loads that fit your truck.

Here's a key idea about lanes: some directions pay much better than others. The strong, busy, high-paying direction is the **headhaul**. The weaker, lower-paying direction — often the trip back — is the **backhaul**. A smart dispatcher chases headhauls and tries not to get stuck eating cheap backhauls.

The single number you'll judge a load by is **RPM** — rate per mile. Take what the load pays, divide by the miles, and you get the rate per mile.

$$\text{RPM} = \text{load pay} \div \text{miles}$$

Our furniture load: $\$3,000 \div 1,000 \text{ miles} = \3.00 per mile ("three RPM")

And the price on the board is usually a **spot rate** — a one-time, take-it-today price that moves up and down every single day depending on how many loads and how many trucks are out there. We dig into reading the board in its own lesson.

4 The Money & The Clock

Let's talk about how the money actually works, because it's stranger than you'd think. The base pay — the money for simply moving the freight from A to B — is called the **linehaul**. That's the core number.

But on top of the linehaul sit extra charges called **accessorials** — money for extra situations beyond just driving. You'll meet a few constantly. **Detention** is money the shipper or receiver owes when your driver gets stuck waiting too long at the dock — usually past about two free hours. A **lumper** is a fee for hired laborers who load or unload the trailer at a warehouse; you pay it, and the broker usually pays you back. And a **TONU** — "truck ordered, not used" — is money owed to you when a broker cancels a load *after* you've already sent your truck. Learn to capture accessorials; it's real money carriers leave on the table.

Now the catch that surprises every newcomer. Your truck delivers the furniture in Dallas. You'd think you get paid that day. You don't. The broker usually pays on **net-30** — meaning the money shows up *up to thirty days later*. Sometimes longer. But your driver needs fuel and a paycheck *now*. That gap — delivered today, paid in a month — is the single biggest cash problem in trucking, and the industry has two tools for it. The first comes right at the start: a **fuel advance** — at pickup, the driver can often draw a piece of the load's pay early to cover fuel and expenses, usually handed over as a **Comchek**, a kind of express-code check they cash at a truck stop. The second comes at the end: that **factor** from Part 1 — after delivery you sell them the invoice, they hand you the cash now, and they wait out the thirty days themselves.

And sitting over all of it is the clock. **HOS** — Hours of Service — is the set of federal limits on how many hours a driver can legally drive before they have to stop and rest. HOS isn't a suggestion; it's the law, and it decides what's even *possible* to promise a broker. We'll do the actual HOS math when we get to judging whether a load is doable.

5 The Paperwork

Finally, the paper. Three documents run the entire load, start to finish. Learn these three and you understand the skeleton of the job.

THE THREE DOCUMENTS THAT RUN EVERY LOAD

Rate con (rate confirmation) — the one-page contract for this *single* load: the agreed rate, pickup, delivery, terms. You sign it and send it back **before** the truck rolls. Until you have a signed rate con, the load isn't real.

BOL (bill of lading) — received by the driver at pickup; lists exactly what's loaded, how much, and who it's going to. It travels with the freight.

POD (proof of delivery) — that same BOL, signed by the receiver at delivery. The POD is the golden ticket: it proves the job is done and it's what lets you invoice and get paid. **No POD, no money.**

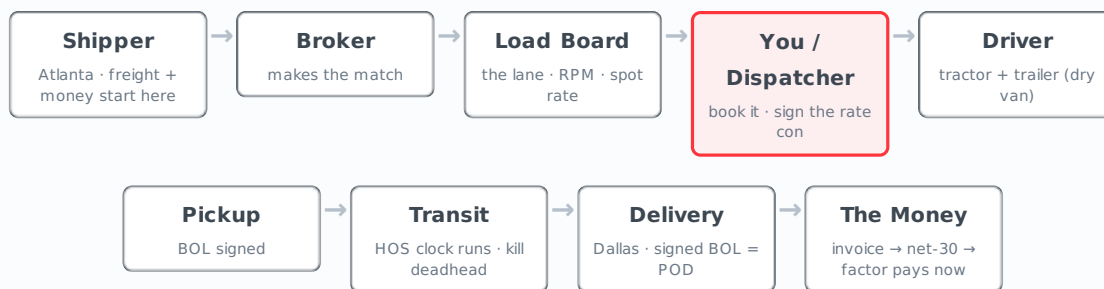
Two more pieces of paper, quickly. Before a broker will work with you the very first time, you send them a **carrier packet** — a bundle of documents proving who you are and that you carry insurance. And your whole identity in this industry comes down to two federal numbers: your **MC number** and your **DOT number**, both issued by the **FMCSA**, the federal agency that regulates trucking. When a broker checks you out — or you check out a broker — those numbers are how.

YOU DON'T HAVE TO HOLD ALL OF IT

That was thirty-some words, and they didn't come at you as a list — they came in order, riding along with one truck from Atlanta to Dallas. You will not remember every one today. Nobody does. What you'll have is **recognition**: when you hear "rate con" or "deadhead" or "net-30" next week, a little light comes on instead of a blank stare. Every one of these words gets taught properly, slowly, in its own lesson down the road. This was the map — and the map is enough for now. Keep the glossary below handy to look up any term, any time.

The whole load, on one picture

This is the shape of every load you'll ever run. Everything else in this course is a zoom-in on one of these stations.



Riding along the whole way: Linehaul + accessorials (detention · lumper · TONU)

Your ID badge to everyone: MC# / DOT# (from the FMCSA)

Module 1 Glossary — your quick reference

The same terms you just met, in one place. Each one gets its full lesson later — this is for looking up any time.

The People

Shipper	The business whose goods need to move — the origin of the freight and the money.
Broker	The middleman who matches a shipper's freight to a carrier's truck and keeps a cut.
Carrier	The trucking company that actually hauls the freight, under its own authority.
Dispatcher	The person at the carrier who finds and books loads and supports the driver — you.
Driver	The person who operates the truck and physically moves the freight.
Receiver / Consignee	The business receiving the freight at delivery. "Receiver" is spoken; "consignee" is the paperwork term.
Factor	A company that pays the carrier fast after delivery, then waits out the slow payment for a fee.

The Equipment

Tractor	The powered front unit — engine and cab — that pulls a trailer.
Trailer	The unpowered box the tractor pulls; its type decides what you can haul.
Dry van	The standard 53-foot enclosed trailer — the most common equipment.
Reefer	A refrigerated, temperature-controlled trailer for cold freight.
Flatbed	An open deck for oversized or odd-shaped freight (steel, lumber, machinery).
Deadhead	Driving empty with no load and no revenue — pure cost.

Finding the Load

Lane	One origin-to-destination route (e.g., Atlanta→Dallas).
Load board	The online marketplace where brokers post loads and carriers find them.
RPM (Rate Per Mile)	Load pay divided by miles — the dispatcher's yardstick for a load.
Spot rate	A one-off, take-it-today price that moves daily with supply and demand.
Headhaul	The strong, higher-paying direction of a lane.
Backhaul	The weaker, lower-paying return direction.

The Money & The Clock

Linehaul	The base pay for moving the freight, before fuel surcharge and accessorials.
Accessorials	Extra charges beyond the linehaul (detention, lumper, TONU, and more).
Detention	Pay owed when the driver waits past free time (about 2 hours) at a dock.
Lumper	A fee for hired laborers who load/unload at a warehouse; usually broker-reimbursed.
TONU	"Truck Ordered, Not Used" — a fee owed when a broker cancels after you've dispatched.
Net-30	Standard payment term: the broker pays about 30 days after a proper invoice.
Fuel advance	Cash drawn against a load's pay at pickup to cover fuel and road expenses.
Comchek	An express-code check used to pay a fuel advance (cashed at a truck stop).
HOS (Hours of Service)	Federal limits on how long a driver may drive before resting — it sets what's possible.

The Paperwork

Rate con	The one-page contract for a single load; sign it before the truck moves.
BOL (Bill of Lading)	Lists what's in the trailer and who it's for; signed at pickup.
POD (Proof of Delivery)	The signed BOL after delivery; it's what lets you get paid.
Carrier packet	The documents you send a new broker proving who you are and that you're insured.
MC number	Your Motor Carrier authority number from the FMCSA.
DOT number	Your federal carrier identifier from the FMCSA.
FMCSA	The federal agency that regulates trucking and issues authority.

Check yourself

Try these from memory first, then check your answers below. The goal is recognition, not perfection.

- 1. Match each person to their one-line role: shipper, broker, carrier, dispatcher, factor.**
- 2. What is "deadhead," and why does it matter to you?**
- 3. Name the three documents that run a load, and what each one does.**
- 4. A load pays \$3,000 and the trip is 1,000 miles. What's the RPM? And do the empty 150 miles your driver drives to reach the pickup pay anything?**
- 5. The broker will pay on net-30, but your driver needs fuel money today. What exists to bridge that gap?**

ANSWERS

1. Shipper = the business whose goods need to move (where the money starts). Broker = the middleman who matches freight to trucks. Carrier = the trucking company that hauls it. Dispatcher = the person at the carrier who finds and books loads and supports the driver. Factor = the company that pays the carrier fast and waits on the slow payment.
2. Driving empty with no load and no revenue. It matters because it's pure cost — killing deadhead miles is a core part of the dispatcher's job.
3. Rate con = the one-page contract for a single load; sign before the truck moves. BOL = lists what's in the trailer and who it's for; signed at pickup. POD = the signed BOL after delivery; it's what lets you get paid.
4. \$3.00 per mile ($\$3,000 \div 1,000$). No — those 150 empty miles are deadhead and pay nothing; they actually lower what you really earn per mile.
5. Factoring — selling the invoice to a factor who pays you now (minus a small fee) and waits the 30 days themselves. (A fuel advance at pickup also helps cover early road costs.)

WHAT'S NEXT → MODULE 2: THE PLAYERS & HOW MONEY FLOWS

That's the language, and the shape of the journey. Now we slow down and start walking it. Next, we go back to the very front of that line — the people — and really meet the seven players who make a load happen, and follow the money as it moves between them. Because before you can run a load, you have to know who's who, and how everyone gets paid.

YOUR COMPANY'S PLAYBOOK

This lesson covers the universal basics every dispatcher needs. Your own dispatch operation adds its specifics on top — the exact load board(s) and software (TMS) you'll log into, who you report to and who handles billing versus booking, and any in-house shorthand for the terms above. *Your trainer or supervisor will fill these in.*